

Pook's Tangled Paths

The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



Pook's Tangled Paths

Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

The May fair was only a day away, and the whole village had been baking and weaving and tuning their fiddles for it. But that morning a worried farmer came running to the Roundhouse: the winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove had gone all tangled, looped over and round with soft ribbons of mist, and not a soul could find the way through to the fair.

Everyone knew at once who had done it. Pook the Puca, a playful faerie who can slip from shape to shape as easily as you change your mind, had been at his games. He meant no harm by it. To Pook, a tangled path is simply the best sort of riddle, and he had quite forgotten that the village folk would mind.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver called the two of you to her side by the warm hearth. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more in the grove than the strongest arm. Will you go and untangle the paths, and win our Pook over with a friendly word, so he sets them right himself?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red wool, a honey oatcake still warm from the hearth, and a small sprig of oak leaves for luck. "Remember," she said, "here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Cleverness, Courage, or Kindness?

Stop 1: The Tangled Grove

You stepped in under the great oaks, and at once the grove began to play its trick. The paths looped and twisted and doubled back, and every leafy turning looked exactly like the last. You walked and walked with great care, and somehow you always came round again to the very same gnarled old oak you had started from.

A traveller without a plan could wander these paths until the moon came up and still be no closer to the fair.

How will you keep from getting lost? You carry a ball of red wool. What might you do with it? Could you tie one end at the start and let it trail behind you?

So you knotted the red wool tight around a low branch at the entrance, and let it unspool gently behind you as you went. Now every step was a step you could undo, and the looping grove could not trap a hero who carried a thread. Before long you found the one path that led on, deeper into the whispering wood.

Stop 2: Pook's Three Doors

The trees drew back and the path opened into a quiet green clearing. There, woven from living oak branches and hung with soft moss, stood three tall archway doors, side by side. Only one of them led onward. The other two, you felt sure, would loop you straight back the way you had come.

With a rustle of leaves, Pook himself popped up: a small furry shape with bright, mischievous eyes and a grin that could not sit still. He loved nothing better than a good clue, and he gave you three of them, sing-song and teasing:

"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."

Which door is the true one? Will you read his clues again, slowly, and puzzle them out together? Pook seems willing to drop a hint if you ask kindly. What do you try?

When you chose the right-hand door, it swung wide on a happy creak, and a warm breeze of grove-smell came through. Pook laughed and turned a somersault clean over a fern, delighted that you had played his game so well. You stepped through into the deep heart of the wood.

Stop 3: Winning Pook Over

Deeper in the grove, where the light fell soft and green, you found Pook again. But he was not laughing now. He sat hunched on a toadstool with his knees pulled up to his chin, looking very small, watching his own toes.

He had made the whole grove into a glorious game, and only now, in the quiet, had it dawned on him that the village folk were sad and that the fair might not happen. He felt a little bit sorry, and he did not quite know how to say so.

This was never a fight. What kindness could you show him? You have a honey oatcake to share. You could sit down beside him on the toadstool. You could tell him there is room for him at the fair too. What do you do?

When you sat beside him and broke the honey oatcake in two and shared it, Pook's bright eyes went soft and warm. "You are not cross with me?" he whispered, hardly able to believe it. "Then I will set it all right, every last tangle, I promise."

The Paths Run True

Pook sprang up onto his furry feet and clapped his paws three times. All across the Whispering Oak Grove, the ribbons of mist came loose and unwound and drifted away on the breeze, and the winding paths fell straight and true, every one of them, just as they should be.

And this time Pook did not vanish into the leaves. He skipped along at your side, leading the way out, prouder of helping than he had ever been of any trick. Down in the village the folk cheered as the paths opened before them, and the May fair began in a swirl of ribbons and fiddle music and dancing on the green.

High above the emerald isles, Danu the Kind looked down through the parting mist and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your cleverness, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Emerald Isles.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes laying a trail of red wool along a looping misty path among great mossy oaks.



Three mossy archway doorways of oak branches in a misty grove, a playful faerie above giving a clue, two small heroes thinking which leads on.



Two small heroes sharing a honey oatcake with a small sheepish shapeshifting faerie on a mossy log, all smiling kindly.



A clear bright path through a sunlit oak grove, cheerful villagers heading to a May fair, a gentle goddess smiling from the green hills, two heroes waving.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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